PHISHING EMAIL ANALYSIS

Cybersecurity Awareness Project
Prepared as a learning exercise using fictional email examples.

1. Aim and Scope

The aim is to identify common phishing warning signs, compare suspicious and apparently genuine emails, and practise a safe reporting process. All five examples in this report are fictional mock-ups; they are not real messages or evidence from an actual organisation.

2. Method

Each email is reviewed for sender identity, context, urgency, link or attachment risk, requests for sensitive information, and whether the message can be verified independently. A message should not be classified using spelling or appearance alone. Check the actual sender address and destination safely, and confirm unexpected requests through a known official channel.

3. Five Sample Email Analyses

Email 1 — Bank account warning

> **FICTIONAL EMAIL MOCK-UP**
> From: Security Team
> Subject: URGENT: Your account will be blocked today!
>
> Your account has been restricted. Verify your password and card details immediately using the link below.

Assessment: LIKELY PHISHING

Annotations / warning signs:
• Urgent threat designed to pressure the reader.
• Asks for a password and card details by email link.
• Sender/domain is a fictional placeholder and must not be trusted as a real bank address.
• Safe action: do not click; open the bank's official app/site independently or call the number on your card.

Email 2 — Unexpected prize

> **FICTIONAL EMAIL MOCK-UP**
> From: Rewards Desk
> Subject: Congratulations! Claim your free phone now
>
> You have won a new phone. Pay a small delivery fee and provide your details to claim it within 30 minutes.

Assessment: LIKELY PHISHING

Annotations / warning signs:
• Unexpected prize and short deadline.
• Requests payment and personal information to claim a prize.
• No verifiable contest or entry details.
• Safe action: do not pay or provide details; verify independently, then report or delete.

Email 3 — Password expiry notice

> **FICTIONAL EMAIL MOCK-UP**
> From: IT Helpdesk
> Subject: Password expires today — sign in now
>
> Your mailbox will be disabled unless you sign in through the link in this email.

Assessment: SUSPICIOUS — VERIFY

Annotations / warning signs:
• Unexpected login link and threat of account closure.
• Sender address alone does not prove legitimacy; display names can be misleading.
• Could be legitimate in some contexts, so verify via a known IT portal or helpdesk contact.
• Safe action: do not use the email link; open the normal work portal directly and report if unverified.

Email 4 — Assignment receipt

FICTIONAL EMAIL MOCK-UP
From: Learning Portal
Subject: Submission received: Cybersecurity Assignment

Your assignment was received at 10:32 AM. Sign in to the portal normally to view submission status.

Assessment: APPEARS GENUINE — VERIFY CONTEXT

Annotations / warning signs:
• Expected subject and details may match a recent submission.
• No request for a password, payment, or urgent action in the message.
• Fictional sender address is not proof of authenticity; compare with the institution's known portal/domain.
• Safe action: if you submitted an assignment, open the portal using your saved bookmark or official website.

Email 5 — Monthly bill available

FICTIONAL EMAIL MOCK-UP
From: Utility Billing
Subject: Your monthly bill is ready

Your latest bill is available. View it by signing in to your account through the utility's official website or app.

Assessment: APPEARS GENUINE — VERIFY CONTEXT

Annotations / warning signs:
• Routine, expected type of message, but context still matters.
• A familiar logo or sender display name can be copied.
• Check that the actual domain matches the provider and that the bill is expected.
• Safe action: avoid unexpected attachments or links; open the official app/site independently.

4. Warning-Sign Checklist

■ Sender address or domain is unfamiliar, misspelled, or does not match the claimed organisation.

■ Message creates unusual urgency, fear, or pressure.

■ Unexpected link, QR code, attachment, or macro-enabled file.

■ Requests a password, OTP, payment, bank details, or other sensitive information.

■ Unexpected prize, refund, invoice, delivery fee, or account alert.

■ Greeting, context, writing style, or request is unusual for the sender.

■ Link text and actual destination do not match (do not click to test it).

■ Message asks you to bypass normal approval or secrecy procedures.

■ Sender identity or request cannot be confirmed through a known, independent channel.

Remember: one warning sign does not always prove phishing, and a polished email can still be malicious. Verify independently.

5. Safe Reporting Process

1. **Stop:** Do not click links, scan QR codes, open unexpected attachments, reply, or enter credentials.

2. **Report:** Use the organisation's approved "Report Phishing" feature or send the message to the authorised IT/security team according to local policy.

3. **Preserve:** Keep the original message for investigation; do not forward it to colleagues. Follow the security team's instructions for attaching or forwarding it safely.

4. **If you interacted:** Contact IT/security immediately. If you entered a password, change it using the official site from a trusted device and follow the organisation's incident process. If financial details were shared, contact the bank/provider through an official number.

5. **Wait for guidance:** Do not delete evidence if IT/security asks you to retain it. Warn others only through approved channels.

6. Staff Awareness Guide — One Page

THINK BEFORE YOU CLICK!

PAUSE
Unexpected urgency? Threats, prizes, payment demands, or "act now" messages are common pressure tactics.

CHECK
Inspect the actual sender address. Be cautious with links and attachments. A logo or familiar display name is not proof.

VERIFY
Open the official app/site yourself or contact the person using a known number or address. Do not use contact details supplied in the suspicious email.

REPORT
Use the approved phishing-report button or contact your IT/security team. If you clicked or shared information, report immediately.

NEVER
Share passwords or OTPs by email, bypass payment checks, or install software because an unexpected email tells you to.

When unsure, don’t interact—report and verify.

7. Conclusion

The exercise shows that phishing may use urgency, unexpected rewards, login prompts, or requests for sensitive information. Apparently genuine messages should also be verified using independent channels. Reporting quickly helps an organisation investigate and protect other users.

References for further reading

• CISA, Recognize and Report Phishing: https://www.cisa.gov/secure-our-world/recognize-and-report-phishing
• FTC, How to Recognize and Avoid Phishing Scams: https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-recognize-and-avoid-phishing-scams
• NCSC, Phishing: https://www.ncsc.gov.uk/collection/phishing-scams

Submission note: Replace or supplement the mock-ups with annotated screenshots created for your assignment, if InternCircle requires screenshots. The sample messages and example domains in this report are fictional.